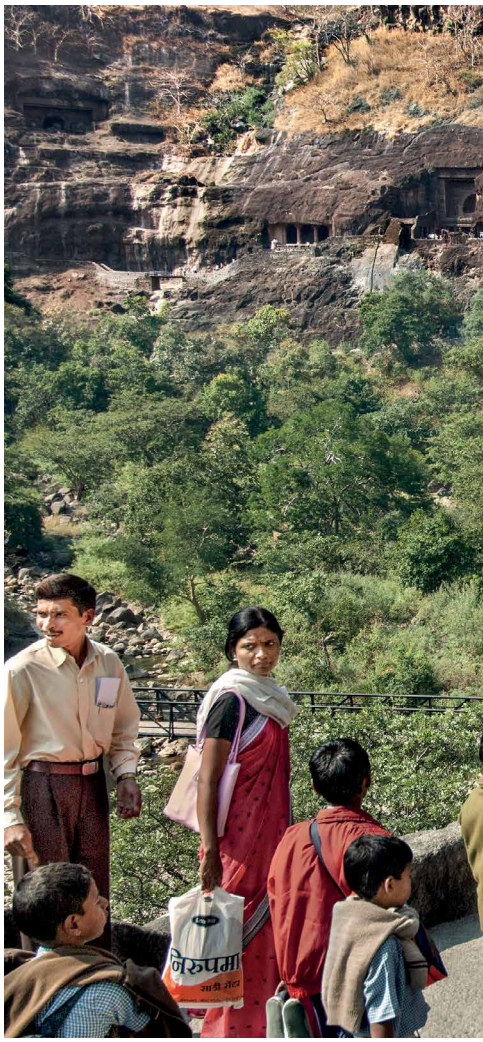
"A man enjoys himself in paradise as long as his memory is green in the world. One should (therefore) set up a memorial on the mountains that will endure as long as the moon and the sun"

— MONK BUDDHABHADRA
Inscription at Cave 26, Ajanta, circa 478 CE



The battle against mortality, in a sense, is inscribed into the very foundational scrolls of Ajanta. An anxiety of perishing haunts and animates the 5th century Buddhist monk's words—aspiring to the eternal, without a trace of irony, in two worlds at once. Over 1,500 years later, that same dread hangs like an invisible nimbus cloud over this little wooded nook of the northern Deccan near Aurangabad in Maharashtra. It might as well: this is a place with no match in the world. On a sheer basalt cliff-face draped around a horseshoe bend of the Waghora river, here stand 30 rock-cut caves of intriguingly graded complexity and beauty. An aesthetic universe that's still only disclosing the secrets lying strewn amidst its stupa designs, curiously evolving floor plans, tiny bas-reliefs and colossal statuary almost liberating itself from rock, exquisitely finished facades and unfinished cells. Clues, hiding in its dim light, that can substantially alter our views on Indian history—the dynamics of power, religion and art as the curtains came down on its Ancient Age.

The past is a magical resource that never runs out: we mine it endlessly to fashion our mental and physical present. India draws from that deep well—a genuine civilisational depth—to water even its modern statecraft. The G20 came to Khajuraho and Ellora in February. Ajanta dropped off that event calendar only at the last minute, through a comedy of errors, but it's easy to see why—if our only use for heritage is to depict it as a series of tableaux—it was chosen in the first place. This ensemble of grottoes has endlessly invited, and defied, hyperbolic cliché—an internet favourite is 'The Louvre of Ancient India'. Covering its walls, octagonal pillars and ceilings—most sumptuously in four caves—are murals of such astonishing delicacy and sensuality as to offer seemingly the strangest harmonic counterpoint to their spiritual function. If the Louvre reference sins by its lazy resort to anachronistic European analogy, the artist Amrita Sher-Gil in the 1930s atoned on everyone's behalf by declaring even "a fresco from Ajanta...is worth more than the whole Renaissance". This painted corpus—49,500 square feet of just the original programmed work—is what is most in peril. Day after day, minute by minute, they confront the exact fate that Buddhabhadra wished to thwart for ever: extinction.

'Heritage tourism' is a compound phrase whose two components pull in contrary directions: one demands preservation, the other seeks exploita-